Strategic Air Command should be placed on alert and two US armoured divisions dispatched down the autobahn to establish a land corridor to the city.

Kennedy also listened to advice from officials who strongly disagreed with Acheson, including Llewelyn ('Tommy') Thompson (US Ambassador in Moscow), Charles Bohlen, and Arthur Schlesinger. Robert McNamara and McGeorge Bundy, as well as Harvard academic Henry Kissinger, also counselled against some of Acheson's proposals. In addition, there were NATO allies to consider. Their opinions diverged. Adenauer supported strong measures. De Gaulle told Kennedy en route to Vienna that if Khrushchev threatened war over Berlin, he was bluffing. Macmillan – and the British chiefs of staff – opposed a military response to Soviet action against West Berlin.

On 13 July Kennedy was also briefed by Allen Dulles on secret intelligence obtained from a source in Soviet Military Intelligence.[23] Oleg Penkovsky was a colonel in the GRU, who was run in a joint operation by the CIA and the British SIS. He provided the West with a huge amount of military intelligence between the spring of 1961and the autumn of 1962. In addition, he had access to senior figures in the Soviet military. DCI Dulles was thus able to relay the comments of the Chief Marshal of Soviet Artillery, General Sergei Varentsov, which suggested Khrushchev intended to sign a peace treaty with East Germany in the expectation that the West would back down. Dulles conveyed Penkovsky's view that it was essential to meet firmness with firmness.[24] Some of the colonel's views accorded with Acheson's recommendations and the idea of responding with firmness reinforced the tenor of Kennedy's speech. To suggest, however, that 'During the Berlin crisis of 1961 and the Cuban missile crisis in 1962, Penkovsky was the spy who saved the world from nuclear war' reflects the hyperbole that has frequently accompanied his story.[25]

Acheson's review required consideration of whether, how, and in what circumstances the President should consider using nuclear weapons against Soviet aggression. In his 1988 book, *Danger and Survival*, McGeorge Bundy recounts that when Kennedy asked Acheson under what circumstances he should use nuclear weapons in a confrontation over